UNIVERSITY OF THE PEOPLE

ENGL 1405-01 - AY2027-T1

Unit 3 Assignment

Submitted by: Mubashir Ali

Instructor: Arnila Gunaratne

Date: September 18, 2026

From Fate to Individual Freedom: A Comparison of Oedipus the King and A Doll's House

Introduction and Selection

For this assignment, I have chosen tragedy as the dramatic genre. The first work is Sophocles' *Oedipus the King*, which belongs to Ancient Greek drama and is included in *World Literature I: Beginnings to 1650*. The second work is Henrik Ibsen's *A Doll's House*, which belongs to the Realist period of modern European drama and is included in *Compact Anthology of World Literature II*. Although both works are tragedies, they demonstrate how the form, features, and conventions of tragedy changed as drama developed across different historical periods (Getty et al., 2020; Turlington et al., 2022).

Plot Overview

In *Oedipus the King*, Oedipus, the king of Thebes, attempts to discover the cause of a plague affecting his city. He learns that the previous king, Laius, was murdered and promises to find the killer. As Oedipus investigates, he gradually discovers that he himself unknowingly killed Laius and married Laius's widow, Jocasta, fulfilling the prophecy he had tried to escape. The recognition of this truth leads to the destruction of his family and his own downfall. The play is therefore a classical tragedy built around discovery, reversal, suffering, and recognition (Getty et al., 2020).

In *A Doll's House*, Nora Helmer initially appears to live a comfortable married life with her husband, Torvald. However, she has secretly borrowed money and forged a signature to save Torvald's life. When Krogstad threatens to reveal her secret, Nora expects Torvald to protect her. Instead, his reaction reveals that he values his reputation more than their relationship. Nora recognizes that she has been treated like a child or possession rather than an equal partner. At the end of the play, she leaves her husband and children to discover her own identity and independence (Turlington et al., 2022).

Compare and Contrast: The Development of Tragedy

The two plays share several important features of tragedy. Both contain serious conflict, a central character facing a major crisis, a turning point, recognition, and consequences that permanently change the characters' lives. In both works, the protagonist's understanding of reality develops through conflict. The difference is that Sophocles places Oedipus within a world strongly shaped by prophecy and fate, while Ibsen places Nora within recognizable social and domestic circumstances.

The tragic protagonist also changes significantly. Oedipus is a king whose personal crisis becomes a public disaster for Thebes. His search for truth leads to anagnorisis, or recognition, and peripeteia, or reversal, as his investigation changes his position from powerful ruler to a suffering and fallen man (Prettiman, 2024b). Nora, however, is not a traditional royal or heroic figure. Ibsen's tragedy focuses on an ordinary married woman confronting restrictive social expectations. Her crisis is primarily personal, domestic, and social rather than political or religious.

Another major difference is the source of conflict. In *Oedipus the King*, the conflict is connected to prophecy, identity, fate, and the search for truth. The audience also experiences dramatic irony because the truth about Oedipus is gradually revealed while he remains unaware of it. In *A Doll's House*, conflict develops through secrets, money, marriage, gender expectations, and social reputation. This reflects the Realist movement's interest in ordinary life and contemporary social problems (Turlington et al., 2022).

The two tragedies also differ in their endings. *Oedipus the King* follows the traditional tragic movement toward extreme suffering and physical and social destruction. *A Doll's House* ends with Nora leaving her home, which is painful and uncertain but also represents her attempt to become an independent individual. Therefore, tragedy in Ibsen's work does not depend on death or supernatural fate. Instead, it can emerge from social pressures, broken relationships, and a character's painful recognition of reality.

Conclusion

Overall, both Sophocles and Ibsen use tragedy to explore serious human conflicts, but they reflect different understandings of what can cause human suffering. *Oedipus the King* emphasizes fate, prophecy, dramatic irony, recognition, and catastrophic reversal, while *A Doll's House* emphasizes realism, social conflict, dialogue, individual identity, and personal freedom. The basic tragic features remain recognizable, but their application changes with the historical period. This development demonstrates how drama can preserve an ancient form while adapting its conflicts and conventions to the concerns of a new society.

References

Getty, L., Kwon, K., Kelley, R., & Thomson, D. (2020). *World literature I: Beginnings to 1650*. Open ALG, University System of Georgia, University Press of North Georgia. https://alg.manifoldapp.org/projects/world-literature-i

Prettiman, C. (2024b). *Technical terms associated with drama* [PDF]. University of the People.

Turlington, A., Horton, M., Dodson, K., Getty, L., Kwon, K., & Ng, L. (2022). *Compact anthology of world literature II*. Open ALG, University System of Georgia, University Press of North Georgia. https://alg.manifoldapp.org/projects/compact-anthology-of-world-literature-ii